

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Results chain

INPUT -> money, staff and materials committed to the intervention

-> ACTIVITY: what was actually done, such as training conducted or pipes laid

-> OUTPUT: what was directly produced, such as kilometres of road or schools built

-> OUTCOME: the change in the target population, such as travel time or learning

-> IMPACT: the wider, longer-term change in access, income or mobility

REPORTING STOPS -> most Indian scheme reporting halts at the output rung

MUST REMEMBER: Monitoring tracks implementation continuously, evaluation judges...

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Classify the statistic

OUTPUT CLAIM -> share of households covered; number of facilities constructed

OUTCOME CLAIM -> water quality at the point of use; measured learning level

IMPACT CLAIM -> market access, household income, mobility over years

EXAM MOVE -> name the rung of the figure the stem supplies before using it

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Institutional map

EVALUATION OFFICE -> attached office of NITI Aayog; constituted September 2015

FORMED BY MERGING -> Program Evaluation Office and Independent Evaluation Office

BUDGET FRAMEWORK -> Ministry of Finance, Budget Division; dual output and outcome reporting

DISTRICT PROGRAMME -> Champions of Change dashboard with delta ranking

LIMIT -> the evaluator produces evidence and cannot redesign the scheme

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Evaluation criteria set

RELEVANCE -> was the intervention the right response to the problem

EFFECTIVENESS and EFFICIENCY -> was the objective met, and at what cost

SUSTAINABILITY and IMPACT -> does the change persist, and how wide is it

COHERENCE and EQUITY -> does it fit other policy, and who gained and who did not

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Coverage discipline card

RULE -> the budget framework does not cover every scheme in every year

OWNER-VERIFIED -> 2026-27 document covers 172 major schemes

THRESHOLD -> an outlay of five hundred crore rupees or more in that document

DISCIPLINE -> cite with the Budget year and never carry the figure forward

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Three budgeting modes

INPUT BUDGETING -> line items; how much money was allocated to a category

OUTPUT BUDGETING -> physical units produced for the allocation

OUTCOME BUDGETING -> the change achieved relative to the allocation

UNFINISHED -> outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence

CLOSE DISTINCTION: Indicator is not target, output is not outcome, outcome is not...

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: District and block programmes kept separate

DISTRICT PROGRAMME -> 112 districts; 49 key performance indicators; five themes

FIVE THEMES -> health and nutrition; education; agriculture and water resources

FIVE THEMES -> financial inclusion and skill development; basic infrastructure

BLOCK PROGRAMME -> 513 blocks in current NITI Aayog material; a finer unit

ERROR TO AVOID -> merging district and block counts or their indicator sets

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Ranking design

ABSOLUTE RANKING -> compares present level; already-advantaged units stay on top

DELTA RANKING -> compares the rate of improvement over a defined period

GAIN -> a historically disadvantaged district is not permanently placed at the bottom

RISK -> baseline understatement inflates apparent improvement

CONDITION -> careful baseline-setting plus independent validation of the data

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Monitoring against evaluation

MONITORING -> continuous, high frequency, typically self-reported administrative data

ITS USE -> rapid course correction while the programme is running

EVALUATION -> periodic, often independent, assesses whether outcomes were achieved

ITS USE -> scheme redesign and resource reallocation after the evidence is in

RULE -> neither substitutes for the other and each fails in a different way

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Method and limit table

BEFORE AND AFTER -> shows movement; cannot separate the intervention from everything else
WITH AND WITHOUT -> plausible counterfactual; the comparison group may differ systematically
RANDOMISED TRIAL -> causal effect for the design studied; limited external validity
QUASI-EXPERIMENTAL -> causal inference without randomisation; assumptions can fail
PROCESS EVALUATION -> explains why an outcome occurred; no effect size
ADMINISTRATIVE DATA -> continuous and cheap; only as good as the reporter's incentive

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Indicator failure modes and corrections

GOODHART -> a measure with consequences is produced rather than observed; use a basket
SELF-REPORTED -> the judged entity generates the number; validate a sample independently
AGGREGATION MASKING -> the average hides block and group failure; disaggregate by rule
OUTPUT SUBSTITUTION -> effort moves to what is counted; add quality and outcome measures
SELECTION EFFECTS -> only reachable beneficiaries are measured; report drop-off
DEFINITION DRIFT -> the definition changes between years; publish definitions and breaks

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Answer spine for an evaluate demand

OPEN -> say what an output claim proves and what it does not, before citing anything

BUILD -> place the evidence on the results chain and name the missing baseline

CORRECT -> state the counterfactual required and the gaming risk in the indicator

CLOSE -> graded verdict about the evaluation design as much as about the scheme

EVIDENCE LIMIT: AUTHORITY / IMPLEMENTATION: Use Aspirational Districts, outcome...